new home. After the AI consultation, she realised that it could be useful in many other scenarios; she has since returned to it often before family ceremonies and major purchases. "What I like is that I can ask very specific questions and immediately understand why a particular date or ritual is being suggested," she says.

"Sometimes people call us and are absolutely certain," says Shukla. "They say, 'I need this *puja*. I have already been told this is my problem.' But our responsibility is still to have the requirement checked by an experienced pandit. A person may be asking for a ritual that is unnecessary or may not be the appropriate one for the situation."

INTERROGATING THE RITUAL

That does not necessarily mean younger worshippers are becoming more conventionally religious. For some, the change is almost the reverse: they want rituals explained, justified and customised. Pandit Shyam Pandey, an astrologer and vedic priest in Delhi NCR, says, "Earlier, many younger family members would sit in a puja because the parents had organised it. Now, the younger *yajman* (devotee) often asks: why this mantra, why this date, why this particular *puja* for me?"

This scepticism, even as devotees seek divine assurance of security, is reflected in their subconscious willingness to find meaning in astrological readings, regardless of the predictions they make. A 2026 study in the *International Journal of Psychology* of 484 young adults in India found that simply using religion in a positive way—for comfort, hope or support—did not automatically mean people had less anxiety. But the devotees who interpreted their difficulties as punishment from God, felt abandoned by God or experienced spiritual conflict, tended to have higher anxiety. In other words, faith can help people cope, but it is not a guaranteed shield against distress, and the way belief is used still matters. This becomes important when astrological predictions begin driving major financial, medical or personal decisions.

Personalised *pujas* prop up this psychological construct by collapsing space and nullifying the need for a family priest in the same neighbourhood. With telephonic consultations, the experience can be strikingly intimate from far away. Aarav Sethi, 31, an IT consultant based in Bengaluru but originally from Delhi, could not travel north when he wanted to offer a Ganga puja in Gangotri, Uttarakhand. Through GangaPuja, an online service, the ritual was arranged there using his name and *gotra* (paternal ancestry). While in Kerala for a business trip, he watched the priest beside the river through his laptop, saw the water flowing behind him and folded his hands in front of a phone screen as he was asked to state his intention in offering the prayer. Afterwards, the platform sent a video of the proceedings and *prasad*.



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PANDIT SHYAM PANDEY
Astrologer and Vedic priest

With booking platform Poojat, devotees can search not only by city and language but increasingly by the nature of the problem—career and business, relationships, wealth, health, legal disputes or ancestral duties. With the average service on the website costing around Rs 1,000, founder Gyan Poddar says that the larger market is reactive. "Most younger users are problem-driven rather than preventive when it comes to praying. They consult a priest after experiencing an issue in their career, finances, marriage or personal life. The priest then analyses their *kundli* and recommends a specific *dosha*-related prayer or remedy."

Personalisation can extend even to familiar annual rituals. "Someone may perform the traditional Diwali *puja*, but instead of automatically doing it at the usual family time in the evening, they choose a specific time during *Simha Nakshatra* (passage of the moon with respect to the zodiac sign of Leo) because that suits their individual astrological considerations," says Vijayshree Kalani, founder of Vandanam, a prayer booking platform which charges users an average of Rs 1,000 for availing its services. "So the tradition remains, but it is being personalised around the person's *kundli* or *graha dasha*. This is no longer limited to marriage, childbirth or buying a house. Even relatively small milestones are being planned this way."

Perhaps that is where the generational shift is most visible. Younger Indians have not invented the *kundli*, the *muhurat* or the remedial *puja*. What they are doing is placing these traditions inside a culture of personalisation and risk management. The prayer may be ancient; the anxiety surrounding it is unmistakably modern. ■